What is a clause?

A clause is any group of words that contains a subject (noun) and a predicate (verb). Another way to look at it is that a clause must have something (subject) performing an action (predicate).

Subject (noun) + predicate (verb) = clause

There are two main types of clauses: **independent and dependent**.

Both of these types of clauses have a subject and predicate, but the difference is that independent clauses express a complete thought, which means that they can stand on their own as complete sentences.

Independent Clauses: An independent clause can be understood if it is read on its own.

Example: Juan walked.

Here we have an independent clause made up of a subject, "Juan," and a verb, "walked." This sentence is complete because we know the subject and the action. Additionally, this verb does not need an object to complete it. However, sometimes, the verb needs an object, or something that receives the action, to complete the thought.

Example: I threw the ball.

First, let's look for the verb, or action, of the sentence. The action in this sentence is "threw." Now, we need to find out who performed the action. "I" performed the action "threw." Now we ask, what did the subject throw? The answer is "the ball," so "the ball" is our object because it receives the action. If the sentence only said, "I threw," the reader would be left asking "What did you throw?" The object is required to complete the thought.

Dependent Clauses

Dependent clauses are different from independent clauses because they rely on an independent clause to express a complete thought. Dependent clauses cannot stand on their own.

Example: If Wendy goes today

The above example is a clause because it has a subject, "Wendy," and a predicate, "goes." However, it does not express a complete thought. The reader is wondering what happens if Wendy goes today. This sentence is dependent on another clause to finish its thought.

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Example: If Wendy goes today, she won't have to go tomorrow.

By adding an independent clause, the thought is now complete. The reader now knows what will happen if Wendy goes today.

1. Simple Sentence

- **Definition:** A simple sentence has **one independent clause**.
- An independent clause = **subject + verb + complete thought**.
- It expresses **one idea only**.

☑ **Examples:**

- The baby is sleeping.
- She reads every night.
- They play football in the park.

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2. Compound Sentence

- **Definition:** A compound sentence has **two or more independent clauses** joined by:
  - a **coordinating conjunction** (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so)
  - or a **semicolon (;)**.
- Each clause can stand alone as a complete sentence.

☑ **Examples:**

- I wanted to go for a walk, but it started to rain.
- He plays the piano, and she sings.
- The sun set; the stars appeared.

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3. Complex Sentence

- **Definition:** A complex sentence has **one independent clause + at least one dependent clause**.
- A dependent clause begins with a **subordinating conjunction** (because, although, when since, if, etc.) and **cannot stand alone**.

☑ **Examples:**

- I stayed home because it was raining.
- Although she was tired, she finished her homework.
- We went inside when the storm started.

✨ **Summary in One Line:**

- **Simple:** 1 independent clause.
- **Compound:** 2+ independent clauses.

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- **Complex:** 1 independent clause + 1+ dependent clauses.

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